STRAIGHT TALK

SKODA AUTO INDIA DIRECTOR ZAC HOLLIS ON THE COMPANY'S STANCE ON SEDANS, SUVs, EVs AND MORE



Q. Sales of sedans have been falling, and yet Škoda decided to launch the Slavia. Why?
Škoda has a rich legacy with sedans. In India, the sales of sedans have been falling because no new product has been introduced in this segment. With the Slavia, we are getting a tremendous response from customers. Our belief that a good product will take precedence over body shape is what drove us to bring in the Slavia.

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Q. Is Škoda betting big on sedans?
We acknowledge that SUVs have a significant market share, but also that Indian consumers have a variety of requirements, tastes and aspirations. We have a rich legacy of sedans in our over 20 years in India—the Superb and the Octavia dominate their respective segments. We believe the Slavia will continue this legacy. However, we aren't betting on a body style. We are betting on quality products, inspiring designs and driving dynamics and providing a great ownership and maintenance experience.

Q. What is the way forward for Škoda in India when it comes to SUVs?
We will have all kinds of products and body shapes based on customer feedback and requirements. Our way forward is not only with SUVs or only with sedans. Quality products, great driving dynamics, hassle-free ownership experience, complete customer satisfaction is our goal going forward.

Q. Your thoughts about the government proposal to make six airbags as standard to all cars sold in India?
Safety is one of the pillars around which we build our product strategy. We are always welcome to policy that is positive for customers, for safety and the environment, and our cars are capable of meeting all active and passive safety regulations.

Q. Your thoughts about EVs in India?
An important cornerstone of Skoda's global strategy is electro-mobility. Many technologies are being developed on as we speak. But it's not just a question of us bringing it to the market—the whole infrastructure, supply system and so on are things that need to be looked after. The moment these technologies have their infrastructure in place, Škoda will have products for India.

Q. What is Škoda doing to expand its reach in the country?
One of the big reasons behind the success of the India 2.0 project is our network expansion. On an average, we have already increased our dealer, service and customer touchpoints by 100% in specific regions and pan India. Showrooms are being added to places we already have a strong presence in. As of now we are present in over 115 cities with 175+ touch points. We are also ensuring we meet the highest quality standards and adhere to a uniform Škoda Auto-imbibed theme of signature architecture, functional interiors, and rationalised business processes with an aim to enhance the overall customer experience. ■